

Washington lawmakers move to limit Flock license plate reader cameras amid privacy concerns

Lawmakers in Olympia push for tighter controls on automatic license plate readers, citing privacy concerns and bipartisan support for new regulations.

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OLYMPIA, Wash. — For the first time, lawmakers in Olympia say automatic license plate reader cameras, including the popular [Flock](#) system, are out of control and that they will try to put new guardrails on how the data is collected and used.

Public hearings were held Tuesday for two bills aimed at regulating the technology, which has rapidly expanded across Washington over the past few years.

Flock cameras, also known as automatic license plate readers (ALPRs) were introduced to Washington state around 2022, with Yakima Police Department among the first agencies to

install the system as a crime-fighting tool.

Now, more than 80 jurisdictions statewide use the technology, including the Centralia Police Department.

"It is simply data points in time," said Centralia Police Chief Andy Caldwell. "We don't know where you're going, who is in the car, we have no idea where you're coming from — it's just a data point we use for investigations."

But last October, the [University of Washington Center for Human Rights](#) reported federal agents accessed Flock data to pull over immigrants. Since then, immigrant advocacy groups have pushed to take the cameras offline.

"Members we work with directly are telling us we don't know if it's safe to go to work that day, safe to go to school," said Guillermo Zazueta with OneAmerica. "And we have to do something about it."

Bills would limit federal access and shorten data retention

Washington currently does not have rules regulating Flock cameras, while states like Utah, Colorado, and at least 14 other states do.

The proposed bills would limit federal agencies from accessing Flock data and require agencies to delete raw data, including pictures of vehicles and their license plates, within 72 hours of collection.

Opponents say that window is too short to investigate crimes.

"The 72-hour retention limit is too short for real-world investigations," said Pasco Police Chief Ken Roske. "A modestly longer window closer to 30 days with strict access controls and audit requirements would protect privacy and enable investigators to identify suspect vehicles."

Lawmakers say concern over surveillance is bipartisan

Senators who co-sponsored the bill said concerns about how the data can be used extend across party lines.

"We've seen reports that have shown how the technology has been wielded against community members without their knowledge," said Sen. Yasmin Trudeau, a state senator from Tacoma.

Senator Jeff Holy, a Republican representing Spokane County, also warned that the cameras can reveal intimate details of a person's daily life.

"What time you drop your kids off at school, when and where you attend religious services, how often, which kind of doctor you visit," Holy said. "It struck me these cameras vacuum up all data regardless of if there is criminal wrongdoing."

Nearly everyone who testified during the hearing agreed Washington needs more guidelines — with debate centered on how strict those rules should be.

